

Working Title

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The image of the piano has had a long history of social signifier. The first pianos were invented in the Medici Court in the late 17th century¹ ; from the beginning, then, the piano has signified wealth. By the mid-1800's, the piano had shifted to a middle-class instrument in London. The novelty had worn off, and London's (aristocratic) musical scenes expected a certain degree of skill from the performer, leaving the playing of the piano to the professional musicians. As a consequence, the expectation that an aristocrat invite a professional - often international - performer to their salon slowly priced out much of the aristocracy from private musical affairs.² Filling in this musical vacuum is the middle-class or bourgeois. Historian Richard Leppert argues that, "[t]o the Victorian bourgeoisie the domestic [piano] was as essential as the dining room table".³ Further, Leppert believes that, to the Victorian bourgeoisie, "[the piano's] physical presence commonly fetishized materiality,

1. Wendy Powers, "The Piano: The Pianofortes of Bartolomeo Cristofori (1655–1731)," *Heilbrunn Timeline of Art History*, October 2003, accessed May 10, 2026, <https://www.metmuseum.org/essays/the-piano-the-pianofortes-of-bartolomeo-cristofori-1655-1731>.

2. DEREK B. SCOTT, "Music and social class in Victorian London," *Urban History* 29, no. 1 (2002): 61, ISSN: 09639268, 14698706, accessed May 10, 2026, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/44613294>.

3. Richard D. Leppert, *The sight of sound: Music, representation, and the history of the body* (University of California Press, 1995), 153.

... [while] at the same time, the music to be played on the instrument was valorized precisely because of its immateriality”.⁴ The piano is thus, by its absence, positioned as class signifier for the working classes - that is, the working classes cannot afford the luxury of the piano.

Frederic Rzewski is by no means a conventional composer. He was born in 1938, and thus many of his teachers were involved in the extreme modernist musics (and politics) of the early 20th century. His more notable teachers include American Composers Roger Sessions and Milton Babbitt, as well as notably politically impassioned Luigi Dallapiccola. Rzewski’s musical language thus is heavily influenced by these 20th-century techniques, especially serial techniques, modal writing, and poly-tonality. More important to Rzewski’s impact and sound is his engagement - particularly in the 60’s and 70’s - with the contemporary leftist and revolutionary politics of the time. With titles, lyrics, and, most importantly, musical thematic references, Rzewski places his music not in contemporary academic spheres - with Stockhausen, or Cage - but rather with revolutionary spheres - with Pete Seeger, Sergio Ortega, Hanns Eisler.

In the Early Seventies, Rzewski met and became familiar with Pete Seeger, who urged Rzewski to perform in concert pieces that the audience would know or recognise. Seeger believed it was essential that the audience have an avenue for participation - physically or mentally - in concert music.⁵ This advice then

4. Leppert, *The sight of sound: Music, representation, and the history of the body*, 155.

5. Frederic Rzewski, *Rzewski Plays Rzewski*, Liner notes, 2002.

informed much of Rzewski's composition. Many of his pieces make explicit reference to contemporary musics, particularly of class struggle. In 1974, Frederic Rzewski and Ursula Oppens attended a concert given by Chilean group Inti-Illimani at Hunter's College where they both heard Sergio Ortega's song *¡El pueblo unido jamás será vencido!* for the first time. Rzewski recalls walking out from the performance still singing the melody, stating "it never left us from that time on".⁶

6. Rzewski, *Rzewski Plays Rzewski*.

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